

wireless data networks, making it unnecessary for many of us to even own a car: “Connectivity will take centre stage in the overhaul of the automotive sector. With advanced technologies like 5G, AI, data, cloud, etc., CASE will reshape the automotive industry by helping it evolve to the model in which individual vehicle brands become much less important than the software and services that surround it.”

Tech firms say that beyond highly automated driving, there will be numerous use cases of CASE, including car manufacturing enabled by Industry 4.0, vehicle diagnostics and personalisation, smart over-the-air (OTA) updates, connectivity and subscription management, car data monetisation, etc. “We believe technology companies are well equipped to enter the Indian automobile market. There are live use cases that reflect the gradual shift from the autonomy of the in-vehicle technology to democratisation basis collaboration between technology companies and vehicle manufacturers,” says Bansal.

88 | According to audit and consulting firm PwC, the convergence of the automotive sector with the technology, media and telecommunications sectors will have wide-ranging impact. And to meet these challenges, automotive companies need to rethink operations from the automom-

tive factory floor to the back office.

And while tech companies like Xiaomi have announced plans to get into EVs, manufacturing at scale is a different ball game altogether. Experts point out that while many would expect tech companies to dominate the auto industry landscape in the coming years, not every tech brand turns out to be a Tesla. Being from a tech background, Elon Musk perfectly sums up auto manufacturing challenges that he had to face while building Tesla cars. “Prototypes are easy and fun, and then reaching volume production with a reliable product at an affordable price is excruciatingly difficult. Our production is hell. There’s nothing harder than mass producing at scale,” he had said in an interview.

Swapnil Jain, Co-founder and CTO of Bengaluru-based electric two-wheeler maker Ather Energy, says: “While the entry of tech giants will definitely boost the supply chain and bring down costs, we strongly believe that building a favourable ecosystem in the country is critical for the success of the EV industry.” Ather recently tied up with Foxconn, a Taiwanese company that manufactures iPhones for Apple, which Jain says will help it develop and manufacture key components for Ather scooters. “The transition to EVs is inevitable and technology will play a pivotal role in the future of mobility. Consumers today want modern, compelling vehicles that provide a reliable and hassle-free ownership experience,” he says, adding that companies will need to invest in technology and enter into strategic partnerships to stay relevant. “Technology is critical in every aspect for an electric vehicle, be it performance or experience, and poorly done tech will make things harder for a brand going forward.”

Today, automotive companies are facing competition from both start-ups and online players. Smaller, more nimble organisations are succeeding in providing transportation services with new business models, agile processes, rapid releases, and a sharp focus on the customer, says Ericsson’s Bansal. “Hence, to sustain this disruption, it is imperative for automakers to reinvent their organisations with digital



“In a few years the smartphone generation will be our primary buyers. For them, the car is the fourth screen after the TV, laptop and phone”

RAJEEV CHABA
PRESIDENT AND MANAGING DIRECTOR, MG MOTOR INDIA



“The most essential factor to build momentum towards connected cars is fast internet connectivity, which 5G will enable”

NITIN BANSAL
MD, INDIA AND HEAD, NETWORKS, SOUTHEAST ASIA, OCEANIA AND INDIA, ERICSSON